

Just push pause?

Airtel's digital TV recorder vs. Tata Sky+. Let the war of the remotes begin

Robert Sovereign-Smith
editor@thinkdigit.com

I'd been searching for a local version of TIVO for years, and when Tata Sky launched their Tata Sky+ service some time last year, I was one of the first to hop on to the bandwagon. With work, travelling and World War 2.5 beta being fought in my living room over who controlled the remote, I rarely got a chance to put on my Manchester United jersey, dig into a bowl of chips and scream "Foul! Penalty! Arrrgh, you blind oaf of a referee...", at my TV, whilst sloshing cola all over the floor. Much to my terrified pet cat's chagrin, this happens all too often now. Anyone know a good cat whisperer?

As wonderful as owning a Digital Video Recorder was, the fact that it was a one horse race made me uncomfortable. Not that I had complaints with the service, but competition is always good for the consumer, and encourages price drops, better service and all-round cheer.

De-bunking the jargon

One simple rule. Ignore it all. Digital signals are digital signals. They're better than analogue and that's it, nothing more. Although you'll hear claims of "superior" technologies, and have jargon thrown in your face about satellite technologies such as DVB-S and DVB-S2, the fact of the matter is it's all pretty much DVD resolution and not HD – except if you opt for HD channels

such as Discovery HD on a service such as Sun's HD DTH service.

I'm going to focus mainly on the DVR capabilities, because if you're just thinking of shifting over to DTH, you're reading the wrong article.

Interface and remotes

Considering that a DVR device is something that everyone in the family is going to use, the ease of use of the interface and remote is pretty important.

Airtel's remote is decently ergonomic to hold, but the button layout leaves a lot to be desired. Tata Sky's remote, on the other hand, seems like a much better thought out and put together implementation – serial channel surfers will like it. Perhaps it's the Sky moniker adding experience and good design sensibilities to the mix, because this round clearly goes to Tata Sky. Button layouts aside, the fact that you can program Airtel's remote to control basic functionalities of your TV, and thus act as a universal remote, shifts the advantage straight back to Airtel.

Coming to the actual user interfaces, Airtel's interface is snazzy-looking with white text on black backgrounds, and the theme's supposed to be changeable, but I couldn't get that to work – early days yet. Tata Sky's theme is a cool blue and white, and perhaps a little easier on the eye than Airtel's default. Although

both have very straightforward menus, Airtel's is a little more nested, and requires a click or two more for some operations. Everything's easy to find though, but something tells me grandma would prefer Tata Sky+'s interface. For most of us though, it's really a no-brainer after about 30 minutes of clicking and exploring the menus. So basically a tie in



Airtel digital TV Recorder

this aspect, with Tata Sky+ just nosing ahead if you're the type to shake a fist at all the confounded, new-fangled gadgets around you.

Connectivity

Airtel wins hands down here, because it's just nice to see an HDMI connector on a device that's mostly going to be used with HDTVs. Although it may only reduce cable clutter, and not really offer any significant picture improvements, since neither is offering anything near HD quality video, I still think cable clutter's reason enough to have an HDMI-out.

Channel surfing

This is an important aspect to the whole DTH and DVR phenomenon. Both offerings have easy to use scan menus that tell you what's on the other channels, without actually changing the channel. What this means is that you can record that *Saas-Bahu* serial without missing a second of your cricket match. When you change to a new channel, the Airtel box lags a bit more before displaying the channel. Not a big deal if you just go to the next channel, but can become irritating quickly when you're channel surfing. Tata Sky+ wins here.

Pause, record, etc.

Here's what you're buying a DVR for in the first place, so read carefully. On both offerings, you can set a 90 minute buffer, which means that if you haven't changed the channel, and are watching a channel, you will be able to pause or rewind live programming up to 90 minutes earlier. Of course, every time you change a channel, this buffer starts filling from scratch, so this is only useful when you've been watching a particular channel for a long period.

When recording, Airtel can be set to record a maximum of 20 minutes before and after the program ends; Tata Sky offers up to 30 minutes.



We've compared satellite services previously:
www.thinkdigit.com/d/dth_services